

more eruptions occurred over the next 30 years, but the volcano was declared dormant again in 2010.

Galeras

Location Southwest Colombia, northern Andes

Colombia's most active volcano is also potentially its most dangerous, being situated near the city of Pasto's 450,000 inhabitants. It is a large stratovolcano, with a peak that is 14,029 ft (4,276 m) above sea level. The area's volcanism dates back at least 1 million years, with a particularly massive eruption 560,000 years ago. This activity results from the oceanic Nazca Plate plunging beneath the continental crust of the North Andes block.

Ojos del Salado

Location Central Chile-Argentina border, southern Andes

This snow-covered stratovolcano has several claims to fame. At 22,615 ft (6,893 m), it is the highest active volcano in the world and the second highest peak of any description in the Americas. A small caldera not far from the summit is probably the highest lake on Earth. Although there are persistent fumaroles on the volcano, and a gas emission was reported in 1993, the last major eruption took place 1,000–1,500 years ago.

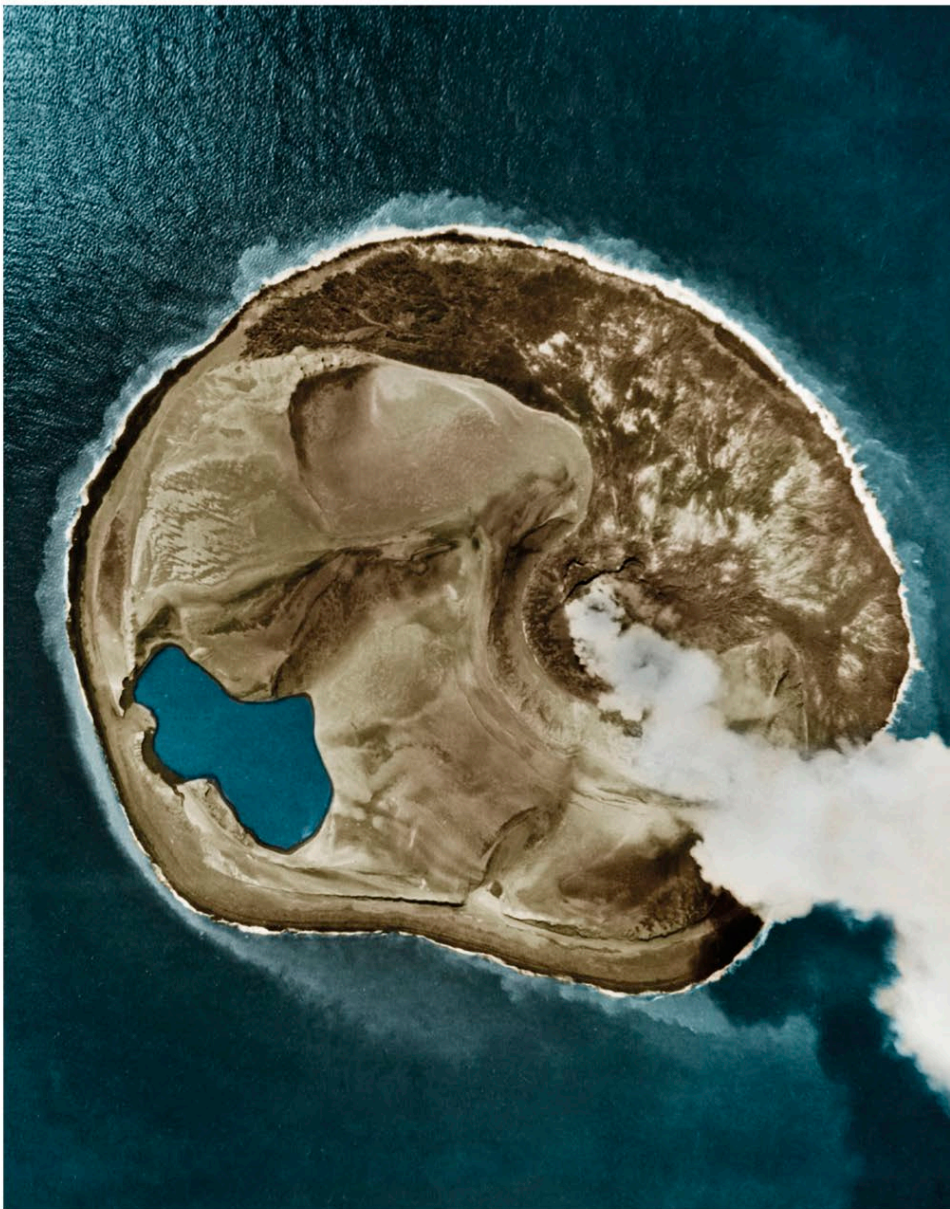
Cerro Azul

Location Central Chile, southern Andes

Cerro Azul is located at the southern end of a volcano chain called the Descabezado Grande–Cerro Azul eruptive system. One of the largest explosive eruptions in South America in recorded history took place in April 1932, when the Quizapa crater of the Cerro Azul stratovolcano released 2.3 cubic miles (9.5 cubic km) of ash and lava in a classic Plinian eruption. At 10,801 ft (3,292 m), Quizapa is one of the world's highest Plinian craters. There has been no eruption since 1932, but small ash clouds are occasionally emitted.

Other mountains and volcanoes in Central and South America

- **The Altiplano** » pp.96–97
- **The Andes** » pp.92–95
- **The Guiana Highlands** » pp.90–91
- **The Hornocal Mountains** » p.98
- **Masaya Volcano** » p.89
- **Santa María** » p.88
- **Soufrière Hills** » p.89
- **The Sugarloaf Mountain** » p.98
- **El Tatio Geysers** » p.97
- **The Torres del Paine** » p.99



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Europe

Grímsvötn

Location Southeast highlands, Iceland

Iceland's most active volcano is, unusually, mostly subglacial, covered by the Vatnajökull ice cap. When an eruption starts, large quantities of glacier ice melt and fill Grímsvötn's caldera. Pressure can then build up sufficiently to lift and puncture the ice cap, releasing huge quantities of water in an episode called a jökulhlaup. During a 2011 eruption, Grímsvötn produced an ash cloud 7 miles (12 km) high, and air traffic was disrupted for several days.

Surtsey

Location Off the south coast of Iceland

In November 1963, a series of Earth tremors, the odor of hydrogen sulfide, and finally a column of dark smoke rising from the sea signaled an underwater eruption off the Icelandic coast. Over the course of several weeks, a new volcano built up from the seafloor, and the brand new island of Surtsey was created, largely of a low-density volcanic rock called scoria. Sporadic eruptions continued until the summer of 1967, when the island reached its maximum size. Since then, wave action has gradually eroded it.